



Outlook

FY27 Budget Priorities

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To Isaac 'Zac' Bears <ibears@medford-ma.gov>; Richard Eliseo <reliseo@medford-ma.gov>

Anna Callahan Budget Priorities

March 11, 2026

Dear President Bears,

I am submitting my FY27 budget priorities ahead of the Committee of the Whole discussion of City Council budget recommendations.

Affordable housing continues to be a number one concern for residents. The housing crisis affecting the entire region is hitting Medford particularly hard, with both rents and home prices rising faster than many residents' incomes. At the same time, climate change is increasing the risks of extreme heat, flooding, and other environmental pressures in our city. These challenges require us to think creatively about how we use the resources we already have and how we mobilize the strengths of our community.

With that in mind, my top FY27 budget priorities focus on initiatives that can deliver meaningful results quickly, at relatively modest cost, while strengthening community engagement and quality of life in Medford.

1. Allocate staff time to advance a Home Sharing program

Home Sharing has been shown in other communities to provide hundreds of units of affordable housing, keep seniors in their homes and aging in place longer, and increase a sense of community, all without any infrastructure changes.

Because home sharing relies on existing housing rather than new construction, it represents one of the least expensive and fastest tools available for us to reach our housing and affordability goals in the City's Comprehensive Plan.

A group of Medford residents has spent the past year and a half researching how a program like this could work in our city and meeting with organizations that operate similar programs elsewhere. The next phase requires active participation from the City.

In FY27, I am requesting that the Administration allocate staff time—potentially through the Housing

Planner or another appropriate role—to begin advancing this work. This could include evaluating potential program models, exploring partnerships with nonprofit or private program operators, coordinating with nearby municipalities that may wish to collaborate, and identifying the resources that would be required to implement a program in Medford.

2. Fund implementation of the Urban Tree Management Plan

Medford's tree canopy is an essential part of the city's infrastructure. Trees reduce heat, absorb stormwater, improve air quality, and support public health. They also help make neighborhoods more walkable and livable.

I commend the administration for completing a comprehensive tree inventory and developing an Urban Tree Management Plan that outlines how the City can protect and restore this critical resource.

In FY27, the City should allocate the resources necessary to begin fully implementing this plan. This includes funding regular pruning and maintenance cycles, watering newly planted and vulnerable trees during dry periods, maintaining and updating the tree inventory, expanding annual planting levels, and investing in the data and monitoring tools needed to track canopy change over time.

3. Support volunteer tree planting

Medford currently loses more trees each year than it plants, and some blocks no longer have a single street tree remaining.

Volunteer planting offers the City an opportunity to expand tree planting capacity at a fraction of the usual cost, since the largest expense of planting trees is typically labor. More than 70 Medford residents have already volunteered to donate their labor to this effort.

To make volunteer planting possible, the City should allocate funding in FY27 for the costs that must be covered by the City in order for these events to occur. This includes purchasing the trees and covering any requirements the City determines are necessary for volunteer planting, such as professional supervision, liability coverage, or staff coordination.

By funding these limited costs, the City will save money by unlocking many thousands of dollars' worth of donated labor from residents and significantly increase the number of trees planted each year.

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Together, these initiatives represent practical steps Medford can take to address housing affordability, climate resilience, and neighborhood quality of life. Each builds on existing community interest and work already underway, and each would help the City make meaningful progress on issues that residents consistently identify as priorities. Additionally, the home sharing and volunteer tree planting efforts are both among the most cost-effective & budget-friendly ways the city can reach its housing and climate goals.

I look forward to working with my colleagues and the Administration as we continue the FY27 budget process.

Respectfully,

Anna Callahan
Medford City Councilor